Ice Age People Traveled and Mixed More Than We Thought

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More than 30,000 years ago, during the **Ice Age**, people in Europe were much more connected than scientists used to think. New **DNA evidence** shows that groups living far apart actually mixed with each other.

A team led by the University of Vienna studied ancient **DNA** from rare human remains and even from dirt in caves.

One important discovery came from a woman who lived about 30,000 years ago in what is now southwestern France. Most of her **DNA** was from western Europe, but some of it matched people from central and eastern Europe. Scientists think these groups mixed about 32,500 to 31,500 years ago much earlier than anyone knew.

Other groups stayed in one place for thousands of years. **DNA** from caves in Spain shows that people **sheltered** there during the coldest part of the **Ice Age**.

"Our results show that eastern and western European populations were not as genetically isolated as previously assumed," said researcher Pere Gelabert.

Word Treasure

DNA -- The code inside our bodies that carries instructions inherited from our families.

Ice Age -- A long period long ago when much of Earth was much colder and covered in ice.

evidence -- Facts or objects that help prove something is true.

sheltered -- Stayed in a safe place, protected from danger or bad weather.

Background you need

DNA is a code inside our bodies that we inherit from our families.

By reading ancient DNA, scientists can tell if people from faraway places were related.

Ice Age people lived in a much colder world than ours.

Break it down

WHO: Ice Age people in Europe, and a team led by the University of Vienna
WHAT: DNA shows that distant groups mixed with each other much earlier than scientists knew
WHERE: Across Europe, including France and Spain
WHY: The scientists read ancient DNA from remains and cave dirt to trace where people came from

Why it matters

This story is about family history too -- it shows people have always traveled and mixed with faraway groups.

Test what you remember

1. What did scientists study?

- (A) Modern maps
- (B) Ancient DNA
- (C) Old photographs
- (D) Weather reports

2. Where did the important woman live about 30,000 years ago?

- (A) Spain
- (B) What is now southwestern France
- (C) Vienna
- (D) Egypt

3. What did her DNA show?

- (A) She was a Viking
- (B) She was related to no one
- (C) She came only from Spain
- (D) She had family roots in western Europe and also in central and eastern Europe

4. When did the groups mix?

- (A) In 2024
- (B) Last year
- (C) About 32,500 to 31,500 years ago
- (D) 100 years ago

5. Where did some people shelter during the coldest part of the Ice Age?

- (A) In Spain
- (B) In big cities
- (C) On boats
- (D) In France only

6. Who led the team?

- (A) A tennis club
- (B) A museum in Brazil
- (C) The University of Vienna
- (D) NASA

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: B 3: D 4: C 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Researcher Pere Gelabert: Said eastern and western European populations were not as separate as scientists had assumed.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):